

Community Action Checklist

Preventing child marriage and supporting girls in Busoga

Treasured Vessels Girls' Centre

Walukuba-Masese Road, Jinja, Uganda
treasuredvesselsuganda.org

Everything on this sheet can be done without funding, permission or training. Tick what you have done.
Pass it to someone who has not seen it.

IF YOU LEAD A SCHOOL

- ☐ State your position on pregnancy re-entry publicly, before anyone has to ask.
- ☐ Name one confidential contact within the school, and tell every girl who it is.
- ☐ Do not identify a returning mother in assembly or to her class.
- ☐ Treat clinic appointments as legitimate absence, not truancy.

IF YOU LEAD A CONGREGATION

- ☐ Say publicly, once, that shame directed at a girl is not the position of this community.
- ☐ Ask openly about the responsibility of adult men. The silence on this is the problem.
- ☐ Make it known that a family struggling with school fees can raise it without embarrassment.

IF YOU WORK IN HEALTH

- ☐ Offer at least one clinic time an adolescent can attend without missing school.
- ☐ Make the confidentiality policy explicit, and repeat it out loud.
- ☐ Know your referral routes for a girl disclosing coercion, and keep them current.

IF YOU ARE A NEIGHBOUR OR RELATIVE

- ☐ Notice a girl who has stopped attending school, and ask why — early.
- ☐ Do not name any child publicly on social media, in any circumstances.
- ☐ Know one number you could call for advice, and keep it.

IF YOU ARE A LOCAL OFFICIAL

- ☐ Make existing by-laws and national guidance known in a form people actually read.
- ☐ Ensure one person owns a case from referral to resolution, so nobody is lost between institutions.

None of this requires a budget. Nearly all of it requires someone to go first.

If you are worried about a girl

Who to call, and what not to do

Treasured Vessels Girls' Centre

+256 756 233 041

+256 774 427 101

CALL FOR HELP

116

Uganda Child Helpline

Free on any network · 24 hours, every day

Ministry of Gender, Labour and Social Development

Also: your district probation and social welfare officer · the Child and Family Protection Unit at your nearest police station · a legal aid provider.

Locally: Treasured Vessels Girls' Centre, Walukuba-Masese Road, Jinja — +256 756 233 041 or +256 774 427 101.

NEVER

- ☐ Name or identify a child on social media — not with initials, a photograph, or enough detail for anyone local to work it out.
- ☐ Confront the family first. It tends to accelerate a marriage rather than stop it.
- ☐ Promise secrecy you cannot keep.
- ☐ Investigate it yourself or question the man involved.
- ☐ Assume somebody else has already reported it.

FOUR THINGS THE LAW ALREADY SAYS

Eighteen is the minimum age of marriage. The Constitution (Article 31) permits marriage only where both parties are eighteen or above, and only with their free consent. There is no exception for pregnancy and none for parental agreement.

Informal unions count. The Children (Amendment) Act 2016 defines child marriage to include formal *and informal* unions involving anyone under eighteen. No certificate or ceremony is needed for the law to apply.

A sexual act with anyone under eighteen is defilement. Under section 129 of the Penal Code Act it is a felony carrying up to life imprisonment. Where a girl under eighteen is pregnant, an offence has been committed *against* her.

Her agreement does not remove your duty. The law does not recognise consent below eighteen for this purpose. If you are weighing whether she agreed, you are asking the wrong question.

General information, not legal advice. For a specific situation, speak to a qualified legal practitioner or a child protection professional. When in doubt, call 116 and ask.